

THE LION

Leo



SIZE RANKING 12

BRIGHTEST STAR

Regulus (α) 1.4

GENITIVE Leonis

ABBREVIATION Leo

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
March–AprilFULLY VISIBLE
82°N–57°S

The outline stars of Leo really do bear a marked resemblance to a crouching lion, in this large constellation of the zodiac, located just north of the celestial equator. It is one of the easiest constellations to recognize. The pattern of six stars that marks the lion's head and chest is known as the Sickle and is shaped like a reversed question mark or a hook. The Leonid meteors radiate from the region of the Sickle every November (see pp.220–221).

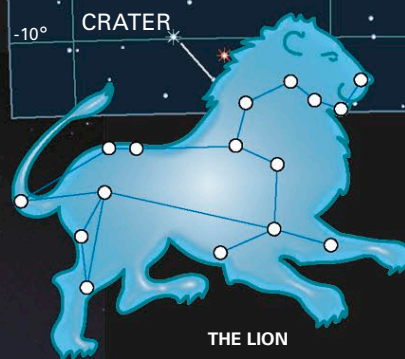
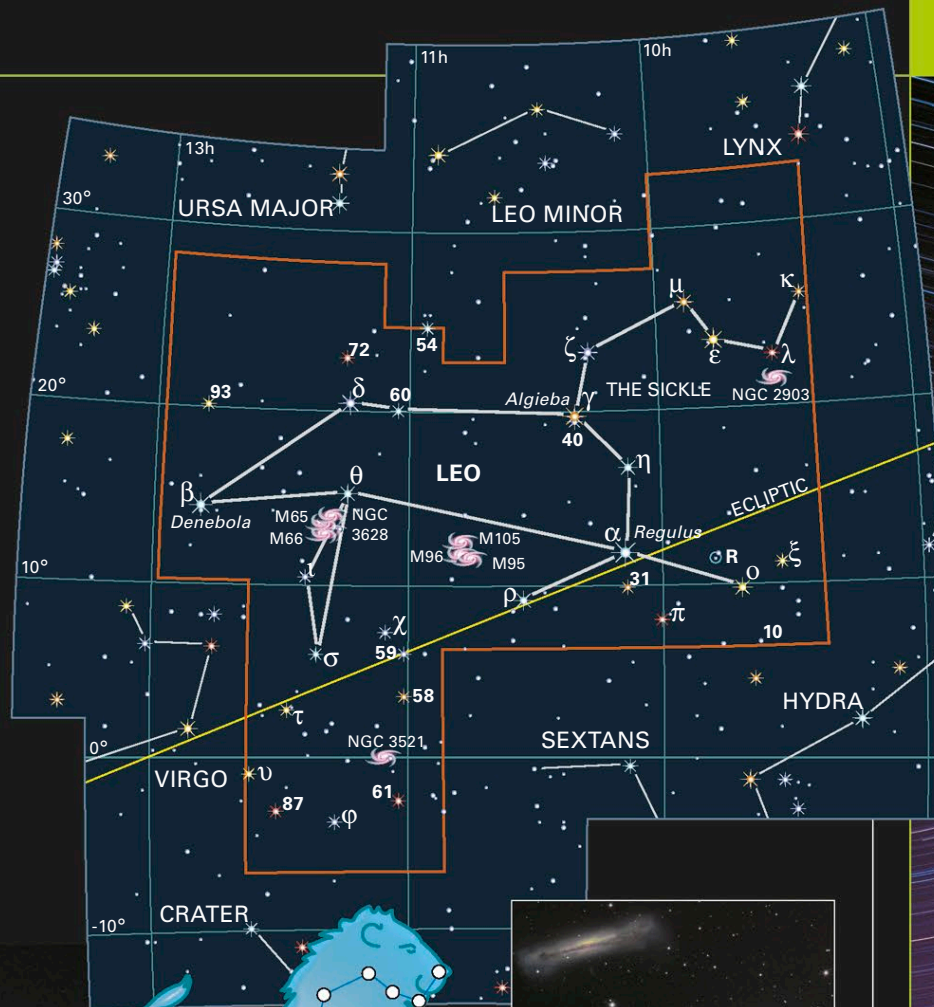
SPECIFIC FEATURES

Regulus—Alpha (α) Leonis (see p.253)—lies at the foot of the Sickle. It is the faintest of the first-magnitude stars, at magnitude 1.4, and its wide companion is of 8th magnitude.

The double star Algieba, or Gamma (γ) Leonis, consists of components of magnitudes 2.2 and 3.5. Both stars are orange giants, and they orbit each other every 600 years or so. A nearby star—40 Leonis—is unrelated.

Zeta (ζ) Leonis is a wide triple star, consisting of a 3rd-magnitude star with a 6th-magnitude companion to both the north and south, which can be seen with binoculars. All three stars are at different distances from Earth and, hence, they are unrelated.

A pair of spiral galaxies, M65 and M66, can be glimpsed with a small telescope beneath the hindquarters of Leo. A fainter pair of spirals, M95 and M96, lie under the lion's body, as does an elliptical galaxy, M105, 1 one degree away.



THE LION

ALGIEBA γ

This beautiful pair of golden-colored orange giants is clearly visible through small telescopes.

LEO TRIPLET γ

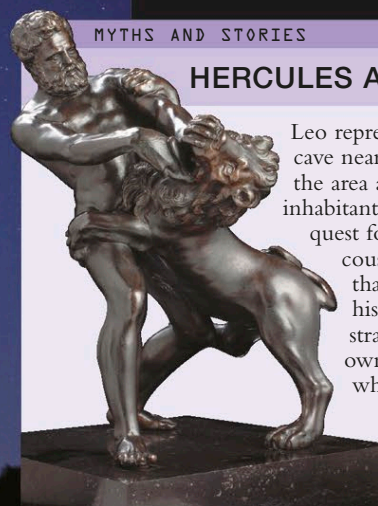
A trio of galaxies lies near Theta (θ) Leonis: M65 (lower right); M66 (lower left); and the edge-on spiral NGC 3628 (top). Although NGC 3628 appears the largest on photographs, it is less bright than the others and is difficult to see through small telescopes.

THE BIG CAT

The crouching lion is a distinctive sight in the night sky. The pattern of its stars is disturbed here by the presence of Jupiter under the lion's body.

MYTHS AND STORIES

HERCULES AND THE LION



Leo represents the mythical lion that lived in a cave near the Greek town of Nemea, terrorizing the area and emerging to attack and devour local inhabitants. As the first of the 12 labors in his quest for immortality, Hercules was sent by his cousin Eurystheus to kill the lion. Finding that the creature's hide was impervious to his arrows, Hercules instead wrestled and strangled the beast. He then used the lion's own razor-sharp claws to cut off its pelt, which he wore victoriously as a cloak.

THE HERO AND THE BEAST

Hercules grapples with the Nemean Lion in a sculpture by the 16th-century Flemish artist Jean de Boulogne, or Giambologna.